

CD-ROMs for those already. These directions apply for CD-R disks and may differ slightly for CD-RW disks.

Before you begin, quit all other applications. The burning process is processor-intensive, particularly when you write at fast speeds. For the best results, reboot your PC before your CD-burning session, and make sure all but your essential apps are closed. Leave your AntiVirus protection loaded, but exit RealPlayer, for example. You should get more reliable (and faster) burns.

In the following steps, we instruct you to create an image file, which requires more steps but will help you avoid creating coasters (useless CDs). However, creating an image file isn't always necessary: If you have a really fast PC, with a 1 GHz processor and 256MB of memory, for example, you could skip the image-creation step and burn directly to the disk.

If you have a slower computer with less than 128 MB of memory, you may also want to burn at a slower speed, such as 4X - especially if you're copying directly from a disk in a CD-ROM drive. It will take longer, but the slower speed makes it less likely that you'll ruin a disk.

8.3 Tips for Your Listening Pleasure

A little effort goes a long way in the digital music world. Here are a few things you can do to improve your experience.

Clean your ID3s. Each digital audio file includes labelling information called an ID3 tag. The tag includes the name of the track, artist, and album. The tag can get even more granular and indicate year and genre. Most players display some of this information, and others use it to sort the files by artist, album, and genre. But the player can't sort correctly if the tags are wrong or incomplete. You can edit the tags through jukebox software or with special utilities.

Make a playlist. The software you use to rip your MP3s can also help you manage them on your portable player. A playlist is a